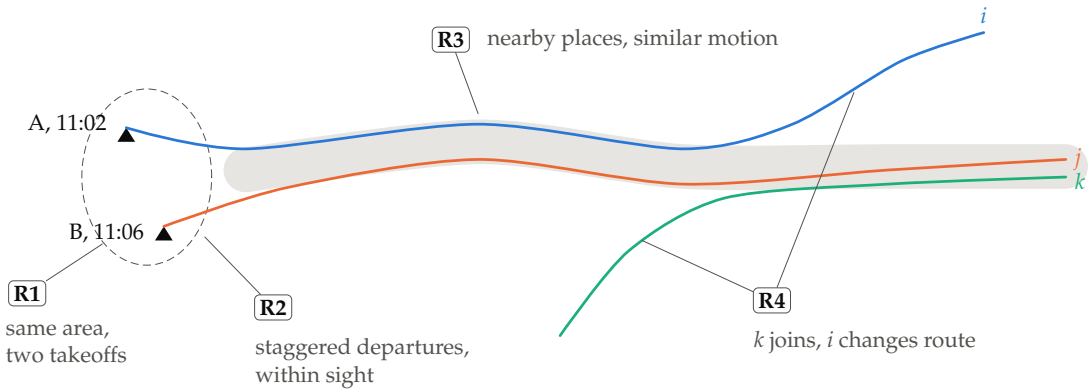
Identifying group flights in the FFVL archive

Part 1: the idea

What the method does, on pictures

The question

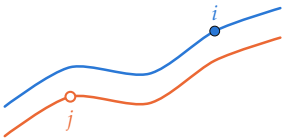
For every flight and every instant: alone or in a group, and with whom?



Pilots in a group need not take off from the same site, like *j* and *k*.

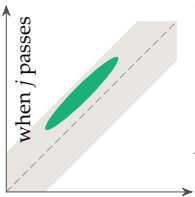
The method in six steps

1 Two tracks



j flies a similar route,
a little later

2 Same place, with a delay



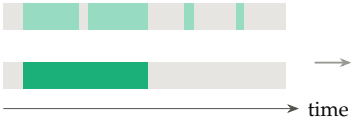
both pass
the same
place;
above the
diagonal:
j passes
later

3 Contact



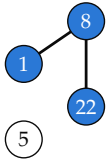
when one of the two pilots
is on the path of the other

4 Long contacts



short gaps filled,
short pieces dropped

5 Configurations, groups



14

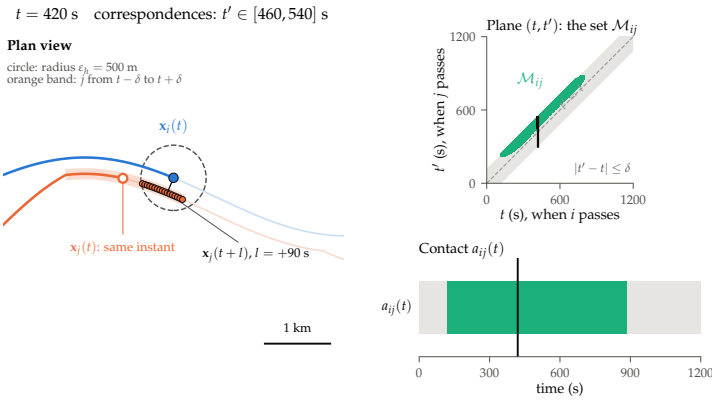
linked pilots:
configuration;
same members
in time: group

6 Episodes



groups that follow one
another, sharing a member

Two pilots on similar routes, 90 s apart

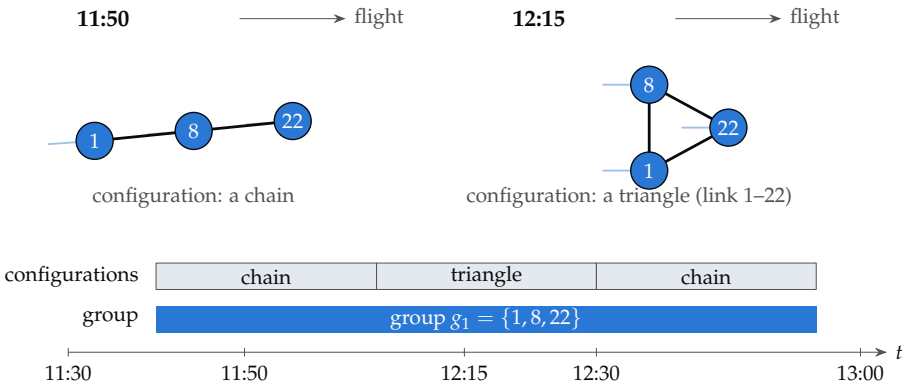


j flies a route similar to that of i, here 90 s later. In reality the delay varies: we want it within δ.

Same instant: here about 0.8 km apart, and it varies too.

Same place (within ε_h), with a delay (within δ): **in contact**.

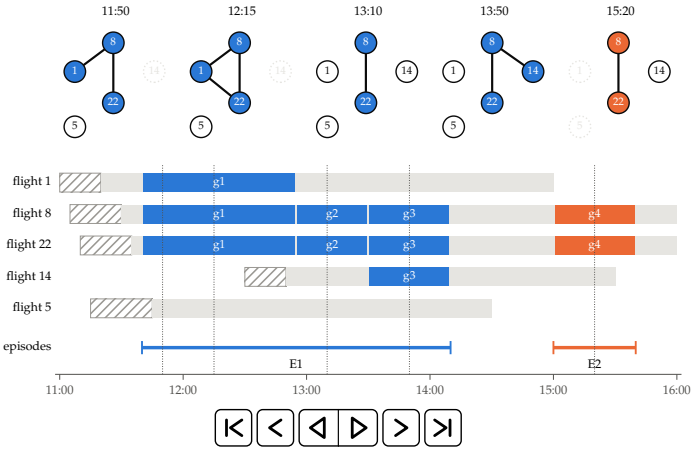
Configuration and group



Configuration: gliders linked by contacts, with their links. A link more or less: a new configuration.

Group: the same gliders, from a start to an end. It changes only when a glider joins or leaves.

From configurations to episodes: an example day



Configuration at t: pilots linked by chains of contacts, with their links.

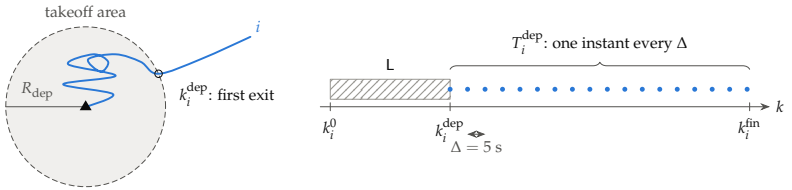
Group: the same members, from a start to an end. An arrival or a departure starts a new one ($g_1, \ldots, g_4$).

Episode: groups that follow one another: each starts the instant the previous ends and shares a member with it (E1, E2).

Part 2: quantitative overview

The same steps, with formulas

Start at the departure



Departure.

$$k_i^{\text{dep}} = \min\{k : \ \|\mathbf{x}_i(k) - \mathbf{x}_i(k_i^0)\| > R_{\text{dep}}\}, \qquad R_{\text{dep}} = 3 \text{ km}.$$

Before it: local phase L.

Evaluation instants.

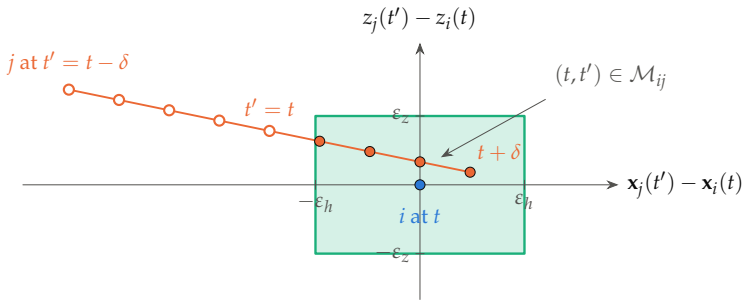
$$T_i^{\text{dep}} = \{t \in \Delta\mathbb{Z} : \ k_i^{\text{dep}} \leq t \leq k_i^{\text{fin}}, \ i \text{ has a position at } t\}, \qquad \Delta = 5 \text{ s}.$$

Correspondence: the same place at two instants

Correspondence. One clock (UTC) for all flights: i at instant t, j at instant $t' = t + l$, with l the delay:

$$(t, t') \in \mathcal{M}_{ij} \iff |t' - t| \leq \delta,\ \ \|\mathbf{x}_i(t) - \mathbf{x}_j(t')\| < \varepsilon_h,\ \ |z_i(t) - z_j(t')| < \varepsilon_z,\ \ D_{ij}(t, t') = 1$$

D_{ij} is the heading condition (next slide).

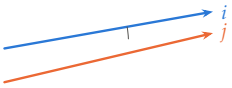


$\delta = 2$ min
$\varepsilon_h = 500$ m
$\varepsilon_z = 300$ m

Heading condition: ruling out chance crossings

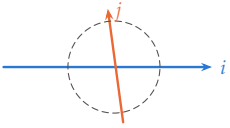
Pilots who cross on different routes pass the distance and delay tests by chance. A group flies the same way.

(a) both glide



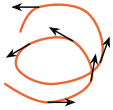
angle $< \theta_{\max}$: ✓

(b) crossing



close, heading elsewhere: ×, excluded

(c) climb or search

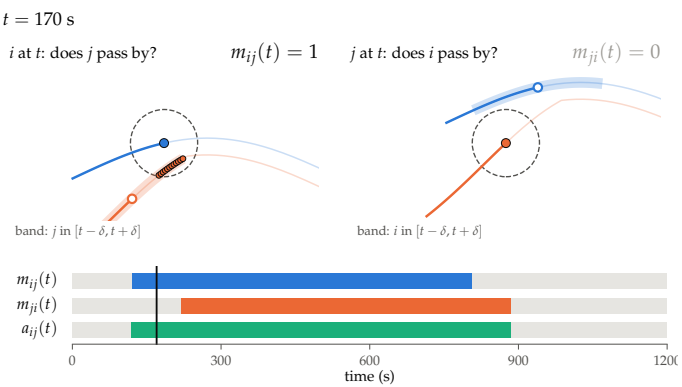


the heading turns: no condition

Heading condition.

$$D_{ij}(t,t') = \begin{cases} \mathbf{1}\left[\hat{\mathbf{v}}_i(t) \cdot \hat{\mathbf{v}}_j(t') > \cos\theta_{\max}\right] & \text{if both pilots glide,} \\ 1 & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases} \qquad \theta_{\max} = 45^\circ.$$

Contact: what i sees, what j sees



Contact.

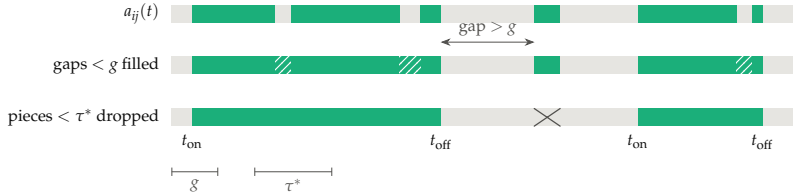
$$m_{ij}(t) = \mathbf{1}\big[\exists\, t' : (t, t') \in \mathcal{M}_{ij}\big]$$
$$m_{ji}(t) = \mathbf{1}\big[\exists\, t' : (t', t) \in \mathcal{M}_{ij}\big]$$
$$a_{ij} = m_{ij} \vee m_{ji}$$

j joins the route of i, 90 s behind, then leaves it.

Start: $m_{ij} = 1$, $m_{ji} = 0$. End: the reverse.

Each alone is not symmetric: the contact is a_{ij}.

Pair intervals: fill short gaps, drop short contacts



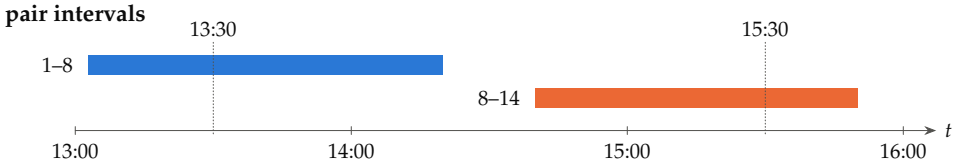
Pair interval. A run of $a_{ij} = 1$, gaps $< \boldsymbol{g = 120}$ **s** joined, lasting $\geq \boldsymbol{\tau^* = 38.1}$ **min**: $[t_{\text{on}}, t_{\text{off}})$.

Choosing τ^*. Not set by hand: we fix $q = 10\%$, the share of kept intervals we accept to be chance. The null model (pairs shifted in time) counts the chance intervals $C(\tau)$ among the $N(\tau)$ observed:

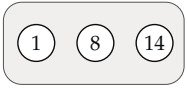
$$\tau^* = \min\Big\{\tau : \frac{C(\tau)}{N(\tau)} \leq q\Big\}.$$

Smaller τ^*: more intervals, more of them chance. Larger τ^*: fewer, cleaner.

Contact is not transitive: three ways to define groups

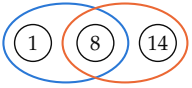


(a) transitive closure



one group $\{1, 8, 14\}$:
1 and 14 never met

(b) overlapping groups



two groups $\{1, 8\}$, $\{8, 14\}$:
8 belongs to both

(c) instant by instant (ours)



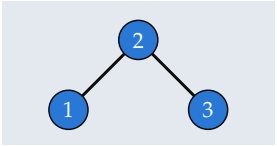
$\{1, 8\}$ at 13:30, $\{8, 14\}$ at 15:30:
one group per flight at each instant

Active graph: the configurations at one instant

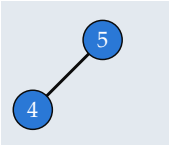
Active graph.

$$G(t) = \big(V(t), E(t)\big), \qquad V(t) = \text{flights in the air at } t, \qquad E(t) = \big\{\{i,j\} : \ t \in [t_{\text{on}}, t_{\text{off}})\big\}.$$

$G(t)$ **at one instant** t



configuration
a chain 1–2–3



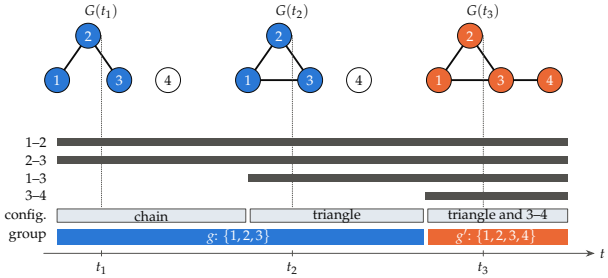
configuration
$\{4,5\}$



solo

Configuration. At t: a connected component of $G(t)$ with two or more flights, with its edges.

Group: fixed members, changing configurations

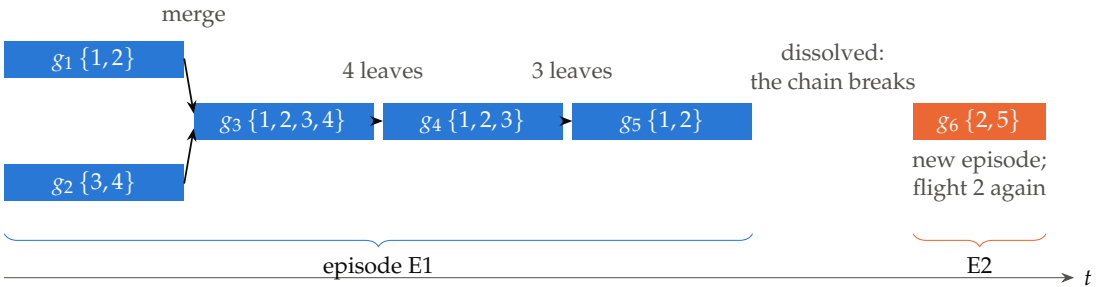


Group. $g = (M_g, [t_g^{\text{start}}, t_g^{\text{end}}))$: M_g are the members of a configuration of $G(t)$ at every t of the interval, and the interval is maximal.

Membership.

$$\gamma_i(t) = \begin{cases} \mathsf{L} & \text{before the departure,} \\ g & i \in M_g,\ t \in [t_g^{\text{start}}, t_g^{\text{end}}), \\ \mathsf{S} & \text{otherwise (solo).} \end{cases}$$

Episode: groups linked in time

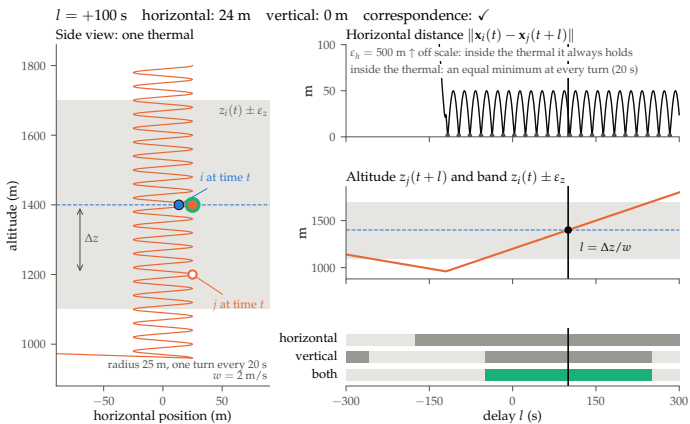


Episode. Link $g \to g'$: g' starts the instant g ends, and they share a member,

$$t^{\text{start}}_{g'} = t^{\text{end}}_{g}, \qquad M_g \cap M_{g'} \neq \emptyset.$$

An episode: groups tied together by such links, directly or through others.

Who follows whom: a label, not used to build the groups



The contact needs only that some delay exists; to say who is ahead we need its value. At t, the delay at which j passes closest to where i is (Li et al.):

$$l^*(t) = \arg\min_l \|\mathbf{x}_i(t) - \mathbf{x}_j(t+l)\|$$

$\ell_{\text{med}} = \text{median}\, l^*$ over a pair interval; $\ell_{\text{med}} > 0$: j follows i.

Glide: one sharp minimum.
Thermal: one per turn; altitude leaves $\Delta z / w \pm 150$ s, against $\delta = 120$ s.
Search: left out.

On the FFVL archive

21.7%
of paraglider flights fly in a group at some point

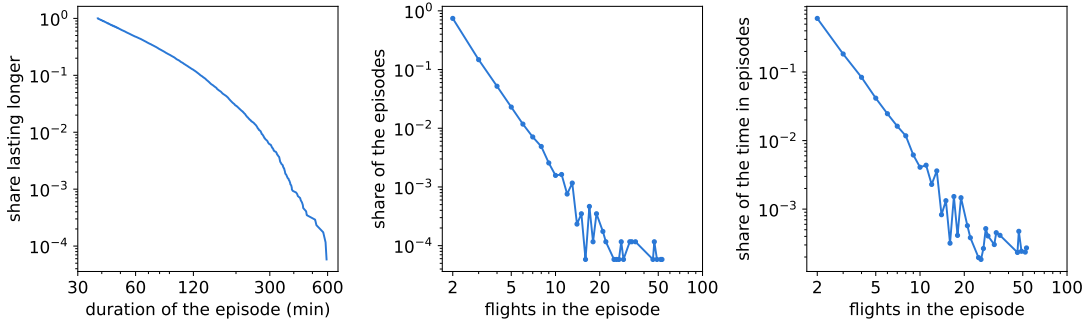
6.9%
of hang-glider flights

17 169
episodes

58 min
median episode; 2 flights (median), up to 53

160 637 flights; $\delta = 2$ min, $\varepsilon_h = 500$ m, $\varepsilon_z = 300$ m, $g = 120$ s, $\tau^* = 38.1$ min.

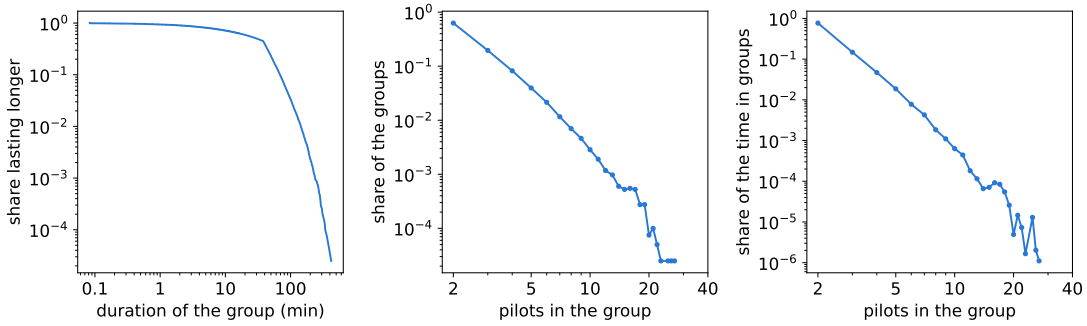
Episodes: how long, how many flights



Whole archive, $\delta = 2$ min, $q = 0.1$. Left: share lasting longer. Middle: share of the episodes of each size. Right: share of the episode time. Size: distinct flights of the episode.

With $q = 0.1$ the median episode lasts 58 min and 74% are pairs. Weighted by time the pairs drop to 61%: large episodes last longer.

Groups: how long, how many pilots at once



Whole archive, $\delta = 2$ min, $q = 0.1$. A group keeps its members; each arrival or departure starts a new one. Size: pilots at once.

Median group 30 min, 63% are pairs. Weighted by time the pairs rise to 77%: large groups change quickly.